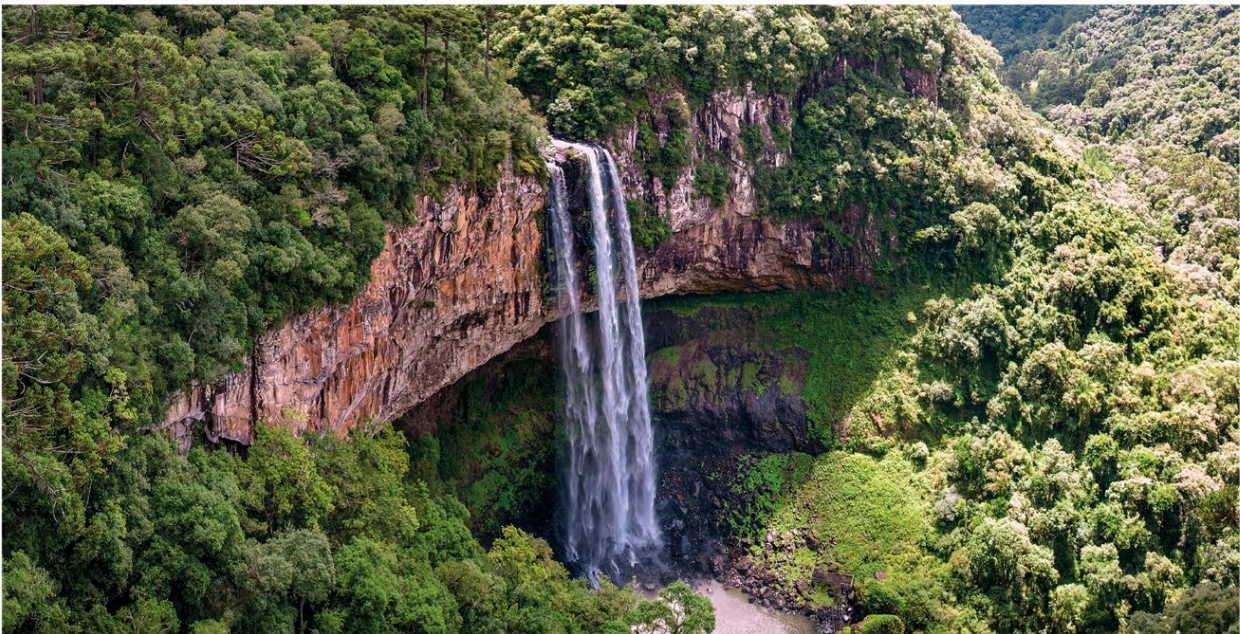




▲ CARACOL FALLS SURROUNDED BY RESTINGA FOREST

Chilean Matorral

Location Between the Pacific Ocean and the Andes, central Chile

This biome of shrubland and forest covers 57,100 square miles (148,000 square km) of the central Chilean coastal strip. It is transitional between the arid Atacama Desert to the north and the wetter Valdivian forest to the south, with a Mediterranean climate of rainy winters and dry summers. It has an enormous variety of plant species, about 95 percent of which are endemic to Chile, including many sclerophytic shrubs (with tough evergreen leaves to reduce water loss), cacti, and fuschias.

Other forests in Central and South America

- **The Amazon Rain Forest** » pp.120-21
- **The Andean Yungas** » p.119
- **The Monteverde Cloud Forest** » pp.118-19
- **The Valdivian Temperate Forest** » p.119

Europe

The Caledonian Forest

Location The Scottish Highlands, UK

Scots pine forest colonized the UK after the last ice age, 9,000 years ago. Wetter and windier conditions later reduced its extent, and grazing deer and sheep have also contributed to the Caledonian Forest being reduced to its present 70 square miles (180 square km), divided into 35 remnants. In addition to the pines, there is birch, rowan, aspen, juniper, and oak. The UK's only endemic vertebrate species, the Scottish crossbill, feeds on pine cones in the forest.

The Jalisco Dry Forest

Location Nayarit, Jalisco, and Colima states, west to central Mexico

Although relatively small, this ecoregion along the Pacific coast of central Mexico is one of the most biodiverse on Earth. Of 1,200 plant species, 16 percent are found nowhere else, and of 733 vertebrates, 29 percent are endemic, including Merriam's desert shrew, the Mexican parrotlet, and the San Blas jay. The Jalisco Dry Forest also serves as an important stopover for migrating birds from North America on their route toward South America. A wet season lasts from June to September, but the region is dry for most of the year.

Other forests in North America

- **Cherokee National Forest** » p.70
- **The Giant Forest** » pp.68-69
- **Green Mountain National Forest** » p.71
- **North American Boreal Forest** » p.66
- **Pando Aspen Grove** » p.70
- **Pacific Northwest Rain Forest** » p.67

Central and South America

Chocoan Rain Forest

Location Eastern Panama and northern Ecuador, northwest South America

This biome of ultrawet tropical rain forest is one of the most species-rich lowland areas on Earth. More than 11,000 types of plants have been recorded, about a quarter of them endemic, and there are 650 species of birds, many of them found nowhere else on Earth. This rain forest covers about 70,000 square miles (180,000 square km) of the zone between the Pacific coast and an elevation of about 3,300 ft (1,000 m) in the western Andes. The annual rainfall here exceeds 512 in (13,000 mm).

Atlantic Coast Restinga Forest

Location Three enclaves in Atlantic Forest, eastern Brazil

This is now restricted to three relatively small fragments of tropical forest in the north and,

farther south, subtropical forest on sandy, nutrient-poor soils that have often formed on stabilized sand dunes. The forest typically comprises closed-canopy broadleaf trees of medium height, 16–50 ft (5–15 m) tall, but there is also an open-canopy variant, more like savanna. Several animals that are dependent on restinga are threatened with extinction. Much of the biome has been destroyed for urban development, and this still poses a major threat.

South American Dry Forest

Location Western Paraguay, southern Bolivia and Brazil, and northern Argentina

Occupying a huge lowland area of sandy and silty sediments west of the Paraguay River, south of the Pantanal, and east of the Andes, this forest type generally grades from parklike savanna in the east through palm savanna to thorn scrub in the west. The change is related to rainfall, which generally decreases moving west, and may be less than 2 in (50 mm) in the west. The plants are tolerant of low water levels. This forest is one of the last refuges of the flightless rhea and other animals, including jaguars, ocelots, pumas, tapirs, and spiny anteaters.